

CULTIVARS

- Salanovas (Red Butter, Red Sweet Crisp, Green Sweet Crisp, Green Incised)
- Ezbruke
- Brentwood
- Avoid green Oakleaf from the Salanova collection in fall (not as frost hardy)
- The cultivars are mixed in cell flats at time of seeding

INTENSIVE SPACING

- 4 rows (8"-20 cm) per bed spaced every 6" (15 cm) on the row

FERTILIZATION

- One cut lettuce will do great in beds that have been previously amended with compost and is fertilized with a mix of alfalfa meal (2-0-2) and pelleted chicken manure (5-3-2).

IRRIGATION

Irrigation Type

- Drip tape (4 per bed) or sprinkler

Irrigation Management

- Root depth: Shallow (6"-24")
- General: Water consistently for succulent growth and to avoid bitter taste.

IMPLANTATION

Mesclun is an important cash crop, but it comes with the challenge of not hitting any shortage of production throughout the season. We seed 3 times the amount of our weekly needs every 3 weeks and plan multiple cuts per planting. We cultivate the one cut lettuce on landscape fabric to prevent weeds and to keep the mesclun clean regardless of the weather. The landscape fabric also keeps the bed clean and weed-free for the following crop.

Our mesclun recipe is 75% cut and come again lettuce (Salanova), 15% baby greens (mostly mini-kale and red mustard) and 10% frisée.

EQUIPMENT

- Rotary harrow
- Popping tray
- Landscape fabric, staples, drip tape and fittings

ITINERARY

- Remove large debris from the bed, if needed (use flail mower, rake, or manually remove the large chunks).
- Apply amendments across the bed and pass with the rotary harrow at a depth of 2.5" (6 cm). To make transplanting easier (seeing as the soil is loose after being harrowed), we only prepare the beds when we are ready to transplant.
- Since the bed is covered with landscape fabric, it does not need to be cleaned up with another pass of the rake.
- If installing drip tape, set out 4 lines per bed and start the system to check for leaks or twists. Fix any leaks you notice at that point.
- Lay down landscape fabric and secured with staples each second step (5' or 1.5 m). It needs to be really tight.
- Use the popper tray to facilitate extraction and transplant the lettuce seedlings as fast as possible. 3 people/100'bed is good ratio for efficient workflow.
- Water the bed thoroughly the first time, keeping the soil moist for the first week after the transplant.

WEEDING

- No weeding required

PLANT PROTECTION

- No action is required.

HARVEST

- Harvesting is done using a VERY sharp knife. Sharpen your blades before each harvest; this will help reduce potential oxidation (browning/discolouration) of the cut surface. For the same reason, never use carbon or rusted blades.
- In a kneeling position, slice through the whole lettuce, cutting just above the growing tip (about 1" from the soil). Leaves should not be any bigger than the palm of your hand (+/- 2" - 5 cm). When lettuce leaves are bigger, cut higher on the plant. Trim any leftover leaves after your cut, making sure the core is clean for regrowth and the next harvest.
- Sorting for debris, rotten leaves, weeds or insects is done in the fields. Take time to thoroughly inspect each handful of cut lettuce that goes into your bin—this is very important.
- Frisée is also cut just above the growing tip, but only the tender heart leaves are kept—discard dark green outer leaves in the field.
- Baby greens are cut using the greens' harvester, or field knives when harvesting second cuts.
- Fill harvest crates to full capacity. Make sure the bottom of the harvest crate is not dirty when stacking the containers—brush off if needed.

CONDITIONING

- In the washing station, place lettuce, greens, frisée and/or any other crop you're using in the mix in its own stack near the bubbler. This will show what proportion of each ingredient you have to mix.
- Fill the bubbler with clean potable water, adding a microbicide sanitizer. The sanitizer will kill any possible pathogens, and will also help improve the shelf life of the mesclun.
- Before starting, wash your hands and/or gloves and sterilize the surfaces using a disposable cloth and an antiseptic soap spray.
- Mix your batch in the bubbler and let it run for +/- 4 minutes.
- Haul the mesclun using orange baskets and spin for one cycle in the washing machine (+/- 3 minutes). The baskets need to be filled at most half way (otherwise the mesclun doesn't dry enough).
- During the first cycle, fill the other baskets so that the leaves can drain while they're waiting for their turn in the machine.

- Empty the dry mesclun into the bagging bin and start bagging while the other drying cycles are underway. And so on...
- When bagging ½ lb bags: weigh within 0.1 lbs (20 gr) so as not to waste too much time. Always leave a bit of air in the bag and tie it twice: the first time very tightly (to close the bag securely) and the second time more loosely (only tight enough to secure the first knot). Each bag must be easy to open so the clients don't have to tear them.
- When bagging 1 kilo bags (2.2 lbs): once filled, bags are sealed using a sealer.
- In both instances, make sure a farm sticker has been put on each bag. Pre-applying stickers to bags could be done in the winter months

STORING

- Mesclun is stored in a cold room at 35 °F (2 °C) and should not be stored more than 3 days before being sold.